> which, like free speech, lies at the foundation of a free society.' *Shelton* v. *Tucker*, 364 U. S. 479, 486 (1960). See, *e. g.*, *Bates* v. *Little Rock*, 361 U. S. 516, 522–523 (1960); *NAACP* v. *Alabama*, [357 U. S.], at 460–461; *NAACP* v. *Button*, *supra*, at 452 (Harlan, J., dissenting). In view of the fundamental nature of the right to associate, governmental 'action which may have the effect of curtailing the freedom to associate is subject to the closest scrutiny.' *NAACP* v. *Alabama*, *supra*, at 460–461."

Under this standard, respondent asserts, the Act's restriction of its solicitation cannot be upheld.

While we fully subscribe to the views stated in *Buckley*, in the very next sentence to the passage quoted by the respondent, the Court went on to say:

> "Yet, it is clear that '[n]either the right to associate nor the right to participate in political activities is absolute.' *CSC* v. *Letter Carriers*, 413 U. S. 548, 567 (1973)." *Ibid.*

In this case, we conclude that the associational rights asserted by respondent may be and are overborne by the interests Congress has sought to protect in enacting § 441b.

To place respondent's constitutional claims in proper perspective, we repeat language used in *Buckley* v. *Valeo*, *supra*, at 13:

> "The constitutional power of Congress to regulate federal elections is well established and is not questioned by any of the parties in this case."

The first purpose of § 441b, petitioners state, is to ensure that substantial aggregations of wealth amassed by the special advantages which go with the corporate form of organization should not be converted into political "war chests" which could be used to incur political debts from legislators who are aided by the contributions. See *United States* v. *Automobile Workers*, 352 U. S. 567, 579 (1957). The second purpose